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RED CARPET: Sarkozy
UPA regime and Paris has been a vocal supporter of Delhi's bid for a permanent seat at the United Nations Security Council, and both countries continue to be on the same page on many global issues. This year Russian President Vladimir Putin was the chief guest at the Republic Day parade, preceded by the King of Saudi Arabia in 2006, and Sarkozy's predecessor Jacques Chirac was bestowed the honour in 1998.

Besides, the French right winger is also looking at the ceremonial honour to pitch for some big ticket defence deals like the one on the purchase of 128 fighter aircraft by the Indian Air Force, and six more Scorpene submarines by the Indian Navy. What better occasion to hawk some armaments than the January 26 parade.

by Saurabh Shukla

The French Connection

DELHI The collapse of the Indo-US nuclear deal has disappointed the French who were hoping to make a killing selling nuclear reactors to India. But India is planning some ceremonial diplomacy to make up for the loss.

The new French President Nicolas Sarkozy, will be the chief guest at the Republic Day celebrations in the capital. The foreign office recently extended the invite to Sarkozy who will combine a bilateral visit to India

along with the Republic Day celebrations.

While the honour is largely ceremonial, given the importance of protocol in foreign affairs it is also a reflection of India's strategic interest in building up a firm relationship with France. Indo-French strategic partnership has grown manifold under the

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

With the Government's image dented by the failure of the nuclear deal, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh plans a makeover by weeding out some senior ministers. The young, powerful but restless Congress MPs are excited.

VOICES



"BJP is least qualified to talk about my moral right to govern. When infiltrators (in Kargil) came into the country, the government was sleeping."

Manmohan Singh, prime minister

"There is merit in the Left parties' argument that for the sake of nuclear power, you need not accept all the conditions imposed by a foreign power."

M. Karunanidhi, Tamil Nadu chief minister

"Sex education has been dragging the children towards crime and if this situation continued, they would become dreaded criminals."

Swami Ramdev, yoga guru

"The nation needs to think: 'Can a sad man lead a resurgent nation?' Neither the prime minister nor his office is doing the nation a favour by projecting him as a helpless leader."

Arun Jaitley, BJP leader

"India has now failed to perform for so long that the game is lesser, because we are missing the artistry and aesthetics that stamped the first part of the 20th century."

Ric Charlesworth, technical adviser of Indian hockey

